Renewable energy certificate standard gets an update to tackle greenwashing

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FULL TEXT

SINGAPORE is updating its standard for renewable energy certificates (RECs) to tackle greenwashing risks, Minister of State for Trade and Industry Gan Siow Huang announced on Tuesday (Oct 27).

The Republic is updating the Singapore Standard 673 (SS673) to specify that companies claiming to use clean power in the country with RECs should ensure these instruments are linked to green electricity supplied directly to the local power grid.

Such electricity should either be from domestic sources, such as solar installations, or from clean power imports.

RECs are market-based instruments originating from clean energy projects – such as solar and wind farms – that companies can purchase to offset their electricity consumption from fossil fuels, to meet corporate sustainability targets.

Singapore Standards are locally developed business standards that can be voluntarily adopted to build consumer trust or access new markets. The update means that companies adopting SS673 should not claim to use clean power in Singapore based on RECs tied to renewables supplied to other countries.

“The updated SS673 will strengthen trust in corporate sustainability reporting and reduce the risk... of greenwashing concerns,” said Gan during her keynote address at the Asia Clean Energy Summit, held alongside the Singapore International Energy Week.

The move is “in line with international efforts to ensure that renewable electricity claims are supported by credible evidence”, and follows feedback from businesses for more clarity on RECs, she added.

It also comes as Singapore aims to import 6 gigawatts of low-carbon electricity by 2035 from its neighbouring countries.

Gan said that the updated standard could make companies more willing to pay more for imported electricity with credible RECs, and thus improve the commercial viability of import projects.

Separately, she noted that as Singapore takes on the Asean chair role next year, it will work with member states to endorse the Asean Regulatory Guidelines for Facilitating Submarine Power Cable Activities, as a key step towards regional electricity trade.

The guidelines are aimed at establishing best practices for subsea surveys and the laying, maintenance, repair and protection of subsea power cables.

Gan noted that clear rules are essential for South-east Asia’s cross-border electricity trade projects to be bankable, and that the bloc’s energy ministers had expressed support for the guidelines earlier in October.

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